Graham Beale

Design Leadership for Human-Centred AI · Design Systems · Research · Accessibility

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Areas of expertise: Design leadership · Human-centred AI · UX strategy · Design systems · User research · Accessibility (ISO 30071-1) · Cross-functional leadership · B2B SaaS and consumer products · Regulated financial services

PROFESSIONAL PROFILE

Graham Beale is a design leader for human-centred AI who makes complex systems work for the people who use them. He has built design functions from an early base three times, at Symantec, Yell and Mimecast. At Mimecast he led design, research and accessibility for a SaaS portfolio serving around 40,000 customers, gave a portfolio built through acquisition one design language through the Mimecast Elements design system, and led design through the move to an AI-first operating model. At Yell he led the research and concept behind the move to a two-sided marketplace; the business built it after he left and it reached a touchpoint NPS of 47. Since leaving Mimecast he has designed and run TurbulentGround, a live product built by a team of AI agents, testing where human judgement has to stay in the loop.

EXPERIENCE

Career break

Independent research, study and civic work | April 2026 to present

A planned break after Mimecast to build hands-on experience of AI-native product work.

- Designed and ran TurbulentGround (turbulentground.com), a live product built by a team of AI agents (product, design, engineering, analytics, QA, later growth) over 17 sprints. Rebuilt its operating model around human review, approval and reversibility; it is now an ICO-registered study of how AI is changing work in product teams.
- Uses Claude Code and Claude in daily work: builds and maintains beale.co.uk in plain HTML and CSS, tested to WCAG 2.2 AA with axe-core, and built a custom WordPress theme for a charity-run pre-school.
- Oxford Programme in Organising for AI, Saïd Business School (May to August 2026). Continued as an elected borough councillor and joined the One Legal management board (see Civic Leadership).

User Experience Director (previously Product Design and Research Director)

Mimecast · Cybersecurity SaaS | September 2020 to March 2026

Led design, research and accessibility across an engineering-led SaaS portfolio serving around 40,000 customers. Joined as UX Director; the title tracked the operating model, from a central Product Design and Research service to designers leading embedded product squads.

- Built an accessibility programme to ISO 30071-1:2019 with Hassell Inclusion, sponsored by the SVP for Governance, Risk and Compliance. Moved accessibility from post-launch remediation into requirements, design, engineering and QA, with the teams using AI to reduce compliance effort.
- Grew the function from four designers, with no research or accessibility capability, to eight people across three disciplines, then decentralised it: each designer became the design lead for one of five product areas, alongside two user researchers and an accessibility lead. Secured and managed a budget of about £300,000 to £400,000.
- Took on a team that had been without a leader for about a year and built a working partnership between design, product and engineering; product managers and engineering teams reported a more productive team. Coached a junior designer to promotion to senior, backed by the platform team's product director.
- Built Mimecast Elements with the platform engineering team: a shared design system in Storybook, adopted as the portfolio standard and enforced by engineering, giving a portfolio built through acquisition one navigation model and design language.
- Built a user research function embedded in product squads and aligned to the NIST Cybersecurity Framework. Turned a long-running customer escalation over deleted data into a cross-product brief on destructive actions; the fix went live in May 2026.

- Wrote the organisation's first UX strategy from interviews with all four product leaders, moving prioritisation from feature requests to outcomes structured around OKRs. Presented it to the CPO and VPs of Product, alongside regular reviews with the CPO and CTO.
- Set how design adopted generative AI: widened the design guild into a UX guild with product managers and engineers, ran trials of Cursor, Lovable, Figma Make, Claude and Vercel, took tool decisions to the CPO, and had engineering train all five designers in Cursor. Used AI-assisted analysis of 120+ monthly support tickets to secure investment in Grafana observability (live January 2026).

Lead UX/UI Design Instructor

Flatiron School · Technology education | June 2019 to September 2020

- Taught UX and UI design to more than 300 career changers on a 24-week programme run through the Canvas learning platform, leading a two-person teaching team. Graduates joined Government Digital Service, Starling Bank, HMRC and others.

Head of User Experience Design

Yell · Digital marketplace and business directory | May 2015 to June 2019

Led UX across three concurrent cross-functional product teams during Yell's move from directory to digital marketplace. Built the design team from zero to six designers, led a copywriter, and built a design system still in use after leaving.

- Set how design, product and engineering worked together through a weekly leadership cadence with the heads of product and engineering across all active workstreams.
- Led a research and validation programme (twelve vertical competitors, NPS data, moderated testing with twelve participants across two user groups) that set a two-sided marketplace as Yell's strategic direction, and presented it to the CEO, CTO, CMO and CPO. The business built it after Graham had left and it reached a touchpoint NPS of 47.
- Designed and developed the mobile free-listing sign-up with the engineering lead. Mobile matched desktop volumes without cannibalising them, roughly doubling free-listing sign-ups.

Earlier roles

Senior Manager, User Experience, Nationwide Building Society (2013 to 2015): led experience design for PayM and Zapp, rolled out to the full app customer base under FCA requirements. Head of User Experience, Everyclick (2012 to 2013). Principal Information Architect, Vodafone (2012). Senior HCI Specialist to User Experience Team Manager, Symantec (2009 to 2012): built the UX function in a newly acquired SaaS division and led a team of five, with CEO Applause Awards for Team Working (FY11, Dashboard) and Innovation (FY12, first iOS app). Senior Interaction Designer, Yahoo! Finance (2007 to 2009), across European and US markets. Interaction Designer, BBC (2002 to 2007), bringing user-centred design into BBC Radio and Music and product-managing the BBC Radio Player on a ten-month secondment.

CIVIC LEADERSHIP

Elected Borough Councillor, Warden Hill

Cheltenham Borough Council | May 2022 to present

Re-elected in 2024. Since September 2026, board member of One Legal, the shared legal service for four councils: turned 14 months of user feedback from seven organisations into 27 prioritised issues and a regular working session with the supplier's product leadership.

SPEAKING

UX & UI Innovation Summit, London (2017). Collaborate, Bristol (2016). Cheltenham DigiTalks (2011, 2012). Falmouth University College (2005). AWS AI Trailblazers Community, by invitation (2025/6).

EDUCATION AND PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

- Oxford Programme in Organising for AI, Saïd Business School (2026). Google PAIR AI Masterclass (2025). BA (Hons) Graphic Communication, First Class, Falmouth University College. PRINCE2 Practitioner.